

Session 3: Engaging in Empathic Conversations

Each mentee you will work with is an individual with unique life experiences, identities, and goals. Making assumptions about any of these aspects of your mentee can create misunderstandings that hinder the success of the relationship. Successful mentoring requires engaging in conversations with mentees that might be difficult or uncomfortable. Such conversations should be approached with empathy, center the needs of the mentee, and result in bi-directional learning for both mentor and mentee.

Things for facilitators to be prepared for:

This session asks participants to reflect on vulnerability, empathy, identity, and difficult mentoring conversations. Facilitators should be prepared for emotional discussions, differing levels of comfort with vulnerability, and conversations about power dynamics. Facilitators should also keep in mind different participation styles and validate responses in the chat as much as those on the mic.

Participant Pre-Work:

- **Objective:** Read and listen to practical advice on having impactful conversations with mentees different from yourself, and be prepared to share your insights and reflections on the techniques and principles presented.
- **Activities:**
 - **Podcast:** [Aiko Bethea on Inclusivity at Work: The Heart of Hard Conversations](#), November 9, 2020, Brené Brown “Dare to Lead” Podcast (00:30:15 - 00:41:30) [[Transcript](#) available]
 - While you may want to listen to the entire podcast, we will focus our discussion on this 10-minute role-play portion of the podcast
 - **Readings:** **Choose one** of the following articles to read:
 - [Martinez-Cola \(2020\)](#), Collectors, Nightlights, and Allies, Oh My! White Mentors in the Academy.
 - [Benishek et al. \(2004\)](#), A Multicultural Feminist Model of Mentoring.
 - [Tanner & Allen \(2007\)](#), Cultural Competence in the College Biology Classroom.
 - Please indicate on the sign-up sheet which paper you will be reading [sign-up sheet](#)
- **Reflection:**
 - What did you notice about the differences between the on-ramps and off-ramps in the role play? How does the identity of both people affect the likelihood of an “off-ramp” during the role-play? What is the responsibility of the person with more power?”
 - Reflect on past vulnerable conversations you may have had as a mentor or mentee. Was the conversation handled with attention and empathy? What were the longer-term impacts on the relationship, if any?

- Write down 1-3 takeaways from the readings/podcast and 3-5 concrete actions recommended in the reading you chose.
 - **Submission:** Be ready to share your reflections during the live session.
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Synchronous Session:

- **Materials Needed:**
 - [Presenter Slides](#)
 - [Participant Toolkit](#)
 - [Session 3 Survey](#)
 - [Survey results from previous sessions](#)
 - Access to Zoom and familiarity with creating break-out rooms.
- **Learning Objectives:**
 - **Objective 1:** Understand the importance of giving vulnerable conversations with mentees time, attention, and handling these conversations with empathy.
 - **Objective 2:** Become aware of the personal barriers that prevent you from engaging in these conversations.
 - **Objective 3:** Explore structures or prompts that can increase the likelihood of these important conversations occurring within a mentoring relationship.
 - **Objective 4:** Learn a set of practical techniques and considerations from the literature that, when put into practice, are likely to improve and enhance mentoring relationships with mentees different from yourself.
- **Reviewing Survey Results:**
 - Before each session, all facilitators should plan to [review the survey results from the previous session](#). This is so they are able to incorporate any participant feedback into their session and make any adjustments.
- **Prework for Facilitator 2:**
 - Set all observers/facilitators as hosts (unless they want to be assigned to breakout rooms)
 - Set up first breakout rooms, random assignment of 2-3 people per room with 13-minute auto-recall
 - Set up screen with 5-minute Google timer, ready to share
 - **Facilitator 2** starts recording, **Facilitator 3** backs up at starting/stopping recording for breakouts
 - **Facilitator 3 starts recording.**
- Note for all facilitators: make sure to rename yourself as “Facilitator” in the Zoom name.

Live Session Agenda:

- **Introduction: 00:00 - 00:10 (10 min):**

- **Facilitator 1** addresses feedback from the previous session.
 - **Facilitator 2** pastes the [Community Guidelines](#) in chat
 - **Facilitator 2** pastes in the chat: “As we get started, type in the chat: What’s one feeling you associate with vulnerable conversations?” If participants come at different times, paste it again for everyone to see.
 - **Facilitator 2** shares the [presenter slides](#) on their screen
 - **Facilitator 1** shares objectives, reminds participants what an “off-ramp” is (defined in the podcast: ways to dismiss the conversation in order to get out of it).
 - **Facilitator 1** emphasizes the importance of mentorship as a 2-way street, requiring constant feedback and clear expectations from both sides.
- **Breakout: Personal Reflections: 00:10 - 00:25 (15 min)**
 - **Activity type:** Breakout Groups
 - **Facilitator 1** explains the breakout reflection.
 - **Facilitator 2** sets up breakout rooms, each with 2-3 participants. They can be assigned randomly.
 - **Facilitator 2** should paste the instructions in the chat:
 - “Reflect on a past vulnerable conversation you may have had as a mentor or mentee. Ask each other in conversation:
 - Was the conversation handled with attention and empathy?
 - What were the long-term impacts on the relationship, if any?
 - How did each party’s identities contribute to the conversation?”
 - **Facilitator 3** stops the recording once they go into breakouts.
 - **Facilitator 2** broadcasts a 3-minute warning before breakouts end and **Facilitator 3** restarts the recording when the breakouts end.
- **BREAK: 00:25 - 00:30 (5 min)**
 - **Facilitator 2** shares their screen with the timer countdown and takes [attendance](#)
 - **Facilitator 3:** Stop recording during break, restarts recording after break
- **Large Group Shareout: Podcast Discussion: 00:30 - 00:55 (25 min)**
 - **Facilitator 1** guides participants through a discussion based on the podcast roleplay. **Facilitator 1** reads each question out loud as it’s posted in the chat and should ask participants to raise their Zoom hand to share.
 - Note: Guiding questions do not all have to be discussed, but make sure there is enough time to discuss both roleplay and mentor questions.
 - **Facilitator 2** shares the instructions and questions that are being discussed in the chat (one at a time) and takes notes of the discussion in the [Participant Toolkit Slides](#). The slides will be shared with participants at the end, so participants aren’t distracted from the conversation and so there’s less pressure on the facilitator typing).
 - “Roleplaying Guiding Questions:
 - [00:31-00:35]What did you notice about the differences between the on-ramps and off-ramps in the role play?

- [00:35-00:39]How does the identity of both people affect the likelihood of an “off-ramp” during the role-play?
 - [00:39-00:43]What is the responsibility of the person with more power?”
 - “Mentor Guiding Questions:
 - [00:43-00:47]What barriers make it more likely for you to “off-ramp” from empathetic/vulnerable interactions?
 - [00:47-00:51]What structures can you put in place to make these intentional conversations with mentees more likely to happen?
 - [00:51-00:55]What questions or conversation starters can lead to deeper mutual learning and a better mentoring relationship?
- **BREAK: 00:55 - 01:00 (5 min)**
 - **Facilitator 2** shares their screen with the timer countdown
 - **Facilitator 3:** Stop recording during break, start recording after break
- **Large Group Shareout: Article Highlights: 01:00 - 01:25 (25 min)**
 - **Activity type:** Shareout
 - **Facilitator 1** will call on participants who read each article, who will share their highlights and actionable suggestions from reading.
 - Note: Ask participants to raise their Zoom hands for each article and leave them up. Depending on the number of participants, ask them to share 1-2 highlights or 3-5 actionable suggestions.
 - **Facilitator 2** will paste the prompts in the chat while **Facilitator 1** reads them out loud:
 - What are the main takeaways you had from the reading?
 - What are the top 3-5 actionable suggestions you took from the reading?
 - **Facilitator 2** shares the instructions and questions that are being discussed in the chat and takes notes of the discussion in the [Participant Toolkit Slides](#), which will be shared only at the end with participants.
- **Wrap-Up: 01:25 - 01:30 (5 min)**
 - **Facilitator 1** will summarize key points from the session and open the floor for final questions or comments:
 - “What’s one suggestion or key takeaway that you intend to try with your own mentees?”
 - **Facilitator 2** shares the link to the [Session 3 Survey](#) in the chat and asks participants to complete it as soon as they can.
 - **Facilitator 1** ends the session by reminding participants of the pre-work for session 4, thanks them for joining and ends the session.
 - **Facilitator 3** stops the recording.

Facilitator Notes:

The Facilitators should spend time writing down everything they observed during the session (what worked, what didn't, and what improvements need to be made). They can also include advice for the next facilitator to watch out for. Facilitators may use the following guiding questions:

- How did the session go?
- Was there active participation in discussions?
- Do you feel like the learning objectives were met?
- Are there topics that need to be revisited in the next session?
- Were participants fully engaged when discussing their own mentoring experiences or goals?
- Were there times of vulnerability, disagreement, or hesitation? How were they managed?
- Did the conversation about group norms seem genuine and open? Were any important issues addressed?
- Are there any organizational improvements (tech, timing, breakout structure) to be addressed before the next session?